

Coder

Matthew Baker

Coder

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In the morning, on the way to campus, I stopped by the building where sensei lived. The tabby cat, a local stray, was sunning in the alley between the pawnshop and the pharmacy. It greeted me with a yawn, stretched, blinked, stood, inspected a clump of weeds, and then slunk off toward the dumpster.

I let myself inside the building with the keys sensei had given me. I collected the mail from his mailbox—junk mail, an operation that sensei said seemed almost quaint in the era of spam mail—then climbed the stairs to his apartment. The rooms were quiet. The furniture, the curtains, everything was exactly the same as yesterday. He wasn't here, and hadn't been.

For five weeks, sensei had been missing. Missing from the material world—his apartment—and, especially concerning, from the immaterial world—the internet. Five weeks before, he had promised to teach me a “legendary very rare technique, invented by hackers in Utah,” but then had vanished the next day. He had left his phone on the toilet, his jacket on the futon, the lamps lit, the shower running. Unusual, obviously. In the time since, he hadn't posted, tweeted, blogged anything. His email accounts hadn't been accessed once. If he had been arrested, wouldn't the news have said?

Today, like every day, I put on a record, an opera, selected randomly from the shelf of

albums above the futon. Opera, that was all that sensei had. Warbling voices, in foreign languages, with cymbals crashing in the background. I didn't mind. At soft volume, that kind of thing could be the perfect soundtrack for doing chores. I rolled up the legs of my jeans, pushed up the arms of my sweatshirt, and got to work. I swept the tiled floor in the kitchen, dusted the cupboard in the hallway, adjusted the radiator in the bathroom, and watered the herbs growing in ceramic pots on the windowsill in the bedroom. That was that. With sensei missing, there were no dishes to scrub and rack, no bags of trash to haul down to the alley below. I wasn't even sweating.

I cracked the windows to let in some fresh air, then heated water in the kettle. Outside, the gutters were streaming with thawing snow—on the wind, there was the smell of wet bark, damp paint, wet soil, damp brick. Taxis honked at taxis. Seagulls wheeled around a water tower. As soon as the kettle began rumbling (“not too hot, for sencha, or the tea will turn bitter!”) I steeped a pot of tea and then sat on the futon, in a patch of wavering sunlight, staring at the door, wishing sensei would come bursting through. I really missed sensei. I sipped, and stared, and sipped, and stared.

Structurally, the source code for every webpage had exactly two elements: the head and the body. Viewing a webpage in your browser, you didn't see what was in the head. The head, that data in there, wasn't displayable. Only the body was. But, still, no webpage was a body only.

What was in my head just then? What jumble of thought and feeling?

<head> curiosity theories anxiety worries </head>

Where had sensei gone? Why had he taken neither phone nor jacket? Was he dead, imprisoned, sick, hiding from government authorities in an underground bunker? Was he

somehow testing me?

I hacked but wasn't yet a hacker. I was an apprentice. I did chores in exchange for lessons. I wouldn't be a hacker until sensei said so.

Was the apartment being watched?

I was dying to learn that new technique.

Outside, in the alley, the tabby was meowing. Hungry for breakfast. The chef was late. I washed the teacup, emptied the strainer, rinsed the teapot, latched the windows. In the kitchen, the window was cloudy, spotted with dried raindrops, would need cleaning tomorrow. From my angle as I buttoned my coat, the windowpane displayed me, a faint reflection.

<body> buzzcut forehead eyebrows eyelashes eyes birthmark nostrils crossbite
jaw </body>

Then I knelt for my backpack, and the windowpane displayed only city.

Somebody had been smoking in the stairwell. The stoplight was signaling go to an empty street. I bought a can of tuna from the bodega at the corner, peeled back the lid, and set the can in the alley, where the tabby was waiting. It sniffed at the tuna, then turned away to examine a pebble, pretending not to want to eat. Today, like every day, it would wait until I was gone.

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By the time I got to campus, my history class had already started. I peeked through the door—the window was embedded with a mesh web to prevent the glass from being

broken—and saw the professor lecturing at the chalkboard, gesturing at the map drawn there, ambiguous territories with smudged borders. The policy was, a tardy counted as an absence. We had been instructed, if we were late, not to come at all.

My grade would get lowered automatically. Still, having to ditch the lecture wasn't all bad. I really didn't like to hear about things like aqueducts and buttresses anyway. Plus, this meant that I could spend some time practicing hacking techniques, and could visit the teaista.

My face was still pressed against the window. A kid chewing tobacco, spitting into an empty soda bottle, was glaring at me from the back row. I tightened the straps of my backpack, slipped out the building, and hurried across campus, heading for the teahouse.

I followed a number of people, but the teaista was my favorite. She worked at the teahouse—the morning shift, today. Wait, what did that mean, “followed”? When other people “followed” somebody, that usually meant subscribing to wall posts, blog feeds, shared images, music playlists. Browsing public content, the few published artifacts of a life. But when the apprentice of an internationally notorious hacker “followed” somebody, that usually meant something far more involved. Hacking private content, mining every last bit of biographical information. The teaista, for example. I read her emails—both inbox and outbox—monitored her bank accounts, watched her video chats, studied the poetry that she drafted and always deleted days later, unfinished. That was my “following.” Stalking, technically. The stalking was nonsexual. She was, after sensei, the central figure in my life.

What was in her head just then?

<head> drowsiness memories loneliness inventories </head>

Cramps had awoken her last night, intermittently. That and nightmares about morgues.

Tomorrow was the anniversary of the date her mother had died, thirteen years ago, which also had been the date of her high school graduation. Lately the looming anniversary had left her dazed, overwhelmed by memories, visions of her mother doing commonplace activities: mopping, choosing a board game piece, rummaging through a purse to pay the fare for a bus. She had been trying to focus on work. She had been feeling distracted. As manager she had to keep inventory for the teahouse—how much flour, how many limes, how much anise, how many eggs remained before an order needed to be placed. She also kept inventory for herself, obsessively. She kept lists of manga she was “dying” to read. She kept lists of her shortcomings. She kept lists of appointments to make, prescriptions to fill, recipes to try, ideas for poems. She kept lists of signs that she was aging. She had not had a date in years. To her roommate, she claimed she “never ever” wanted to get married. To her sister, who was married, she admitted she “desperately” wanted to find somebody, and was losing hope she ever would. She fell asleep clinging to pillows, pretending the lumps were a body.

The teahouse sat on a street of absolutely ordinary houses. Brick walkways, plastic trash barrels, bicycles chained to iron fences. A mangy dog sniffing a manhole cover. There was no sign to indicate that the teahouse was a business rather than a residence. Or were the other houses on this street also unidentified businesses? I had never tried any of the other doors.

The gate was open. Patches of shade from the maple trees were changing shape like clouds across the patio. I twisted the doorknob, stepped through the door.

Inside, an elderly couple sat murmuring at a weathered table with mismatched stools. Steam wisped from the rims of their teacups. Otherwise the tables were empty. The teahouse had an ambience of darkness: a ceiling of exposed wooden beams, walls hung with shelves of clay teapots and iron trivets, a floor of scuffed wooden planks. Dust floated

through rays of sunlight, glittering. Aside from the register—which was plastered with stickers promoting anarchy and burlesque and deejays and marijuana—the countertop was furnished only with ikebana and bonsai in stone pots. The arrangement of flowers, the cultivation of trees, both could be forms of art, just like hacking. Sensei said that there were no superior or inferior forms, that every form had something to teach us about our own. Before sensei had taken me here, I had never even known the teahouse existed.

The teaista was leaning on the register, eyes shut, nodding off.

<body> updo furrows <object>mascara</object> eyelids cheeks lips
<object>pencil</object> <object>lipring</object> throat collarbone
<object>blouse</object> wrists knuckles fingernails </body>

She had a habit of chewing pencils, which her sister nagged her about constantly. Today she had felt like wearing a sweater, but also had felt gross, had overslept and then had woken “feeling hideous,” and consequently “vulnerable,” and “pathetic,” and “weak,” and so had chosen the blouse, with its petite bow and its buttoned cuffs, instead. As “fashion armor,” to protect herself “from the world.” She had messaged her roommate about borrowing the blouse while biking to the teahouse. Her sister nagged her about that too—typing while biking—along with snorting while laughing, and reading while cooking. She often confused, in her messages, than and then, affect and effect, loose and lose and dessert and desert. She misspelled the names of celebrities. She used emoji and emoticons unsparingly. Her comebacks were inspired.

By the time the door had shut and the chime hanging there had jingled, her features had updated, her eyes fluttered open. She set the pencil on a newspaper—an unfinished crossword, eraser shavings clumped together at the creases—and yawned, then grabbed a

menu from the stack. I chose the table in the corner, nearest to the outlet, settling onto a wobbly stool, and, without speaking, only pointing, ordered a lemon currant scone and a cup of matcha. Wearily, she took away the menu.

Sunlight had warmed the tabletop. Even in here you could smell the thawing. While the teaista heated water in the kitchen, I plugged in and powered on my computer. The elderly couple was finishing the remains of a sesame cookie, pinching crumbs from a plate.

Before doing any work, I searched online for signs of sensei.

His sites hadn't been updated. No posting, tweeting, blogging whatsoever. Just the same old post from five weeks before: "who yearns for gyahaha and kyahaha?" The same tweet: "all your brain are belong to us!" On his blog, the same entry, the same title: "on capital- isn't and communisn't." Were these his final words? Were there double, triple, quadruple meanings? Was some message hidden there, in anagram, in cipher?

Probably there was no hidden message, only single meanings, his typical offhand remarks.

One by one, I logged in to his accounts. Acquiring his passwords hadn't required any hacking. Like the keys, sensei had given me his passwords two years ago, back when he had agreed to become my sensei. His passwords were all in leet: "11b3r7y," "3qu4l17y," "ju571c3." Very sensei. A pain to type.

Nothing had been downloaded from or uploaded to his storage account. He hadn't bought anything, anywhere. Nobody had accessed his email account, except for me, yesterday.

So then sensei was still missing.

I put the screen on screensaver, slumped back against the wall, watched pigeons with speckled plumage hop around the patio beyond the windows. Where had sensei gone? Before vanishing, he had been at work on assembling a botnet of absolutely staggering

proportions for a coordinated attack on the stock exchange. We belonged to a collective of anonymous hacktivists. At marches and protests we all wore masks of the same identical goateed face. I had my mask in my backpack, currently, zipped in with notepads and textbooks. Sensei had left his mask in his bedroom, lying on his nightstand, along with his computer. Sometimes I worried I should have been trying harder to find him. He had no relatives, except for those in cemeteries. He had no friends, only associates. If I didn't find him, nobody would. But what else was there? What else could I do?

If he were dead, I would probably never recover.

The dingy velvet curtain that separated the kitchen from the parlor ruffled. The teaista brought out a copper kettle, a stoneware bowl, a linen cloth, a bamboo whisk, an ivory scoop, a tin of matcha, a plate with a scone. Balancing everything, she wore the grim focused expression of an acrobat performing a tightrope maneuver famous for killing acrobats. She relished the danger—the teetering bowl, the slipping cloth—and took pride in her ability to carry numerous objects simultaneously, to serve “any order, no matter how large, in one trip,” although she also felt “dumb” about being proud of “something so ordinary.” She stepped gingerly across the parlor, skirting tables, nudging chairs.

One by one, she installed everything onto the tabletop, except the kettle. “Here’s your tea,” she said, in a casual voice, avoiding glancing at me, trying to hide the thrill she didn’t know I knew she felt. I did like matcha, but that wasn’t why I always ordered matcha here. I always ordered matcha because I knew that making matcha, preparing that specific tea, was what she considered her “reason for living.” I loved watching her remember that.

She began. Throughout the procedure her movements were elegant, precise. Tipping the kettle with a flourish, she poured a splash of water into the bowl, spilling nothing. She waited for the stoneware to heat—testing with fingertips, touching the bowl, impatiently—then dumped the water out. With brisk swoops, she dried the bowl with the cloth. Then,

swiftly, while the stoneware was still hot, she scooped matcha into the bowl, a quick flick of bright powder. Again she tipped the kettle, pouring water over the matcha, almost filling the bowl. Then, finally, she whisked the mixture, fiercely, in a zigzag motion, until the matcha frothed.

Afterward—still gripping the whisk, squinting into the sunlight—she took a moment to scrutinize her handiwork, standing gazing at the bowl. To her my presence there meant nothing. Whether anybody drank the matcha was meaningless. Whether I, in tasting the matcha, managed or failed to recognize her achievement, her degree of mastery, was meaningless. What had meaning was the act itself. She had prepared the tea perfectly.

“So, there you go,” she said, without looking at me. She massaged her neck—with stiff arched fingers, at the spot where her skin met her hair, lately she had been suffering from pains there—then carried the kettle, the cloth, the whisk, the scoop, the tin, back through the curtain, scowling proudly.

I sipped the matcha, nibbled at the scone. The creamy grassy flavor of the matcha relaxed my entire body, from scalp to soles, instantaneously. The scone was still warm from the oven—beneath the currant and the lemon, I could taste dollops of butter, streaks of cream, bursts of vanilla, chunks of salt. Suddenly I was very glad to be alive in this nation, with this teahouse, in this body, with this tongue. Well, enough about ecstasy. I got to work.

I had homework—an essay for econ, a poli-sci exam to study for, something due soon for history—but, like always, I shelved the homework in favor of hacking. I didn’t care if I flunked out of college, if that was what becoming a hacker took. I would have sacrificed anything. Weekdays, I trained seven hours per day. On weekends, I trained closer to eleven. With sensei gone, my progress had slowed—for every breakthrough, there were countless setbacks—but that only made me more determined to keep training.

The past few weeks, I had been working on a script, a program designed to hack the servers of a private hospital in Connecticut. I was stuck though. The script didn't work. I couldn't figure out what was wrong. I had spent days already poring through the lines of code, looking for the problem. The script seemed functional. The script was broken. I had never attempted to hack anything on the scale of a hospital before, and the potential consequences terrified me. A hospital would have honeypots, honeytokens, deadly network security. The script didn't just need to work. The script needed to be perfect.

I was troubleshooting—posting queries, skimming tutorials—when the chime jingled as somebody stepped through the door.

The teaista peeked from the kitchen into the parlor, smirked; her sister had come to visit, carrying a paper sack.

This was an incredible bonus: I hardly ever got the chance to see her sister in person.

They chatted at the curtain—about the weather, an obscure musician, an upcoming wedding. Her sister told an anecdote about lactating, which made the teaista laugh, then snort. Her sister pretended to be horrified. “If you want to get asked out, that snorting has got to stop!” her sister clucked, shifting the paper sack. The elderly couple—perhaps prompted by the anecdote about lactating—was gathering a pair of jackets from the hooks along the door.

The teaista headed toward the counter with her sister. They made plans to visit the cemetery tomorrow for the anniversary. Beforehand they would buy a bouquet for the grave. Her sister had to go, waved goodbye, swung open the door, and walked out—then walked back inside. “I almost forgot!” her sister cried, rummaging through the paper sack. Manga emerged—the cover tattered, pages warped with water damage—a new volume, which her sister had bought that morning, briefly used as a coaster, dropped once in a gutter, obliterated a spider with, and already finished reading. “You won't believe what

happens!” her sister hissed, waving the manga. The teaista snatched it, then shooed her sister toward the door, clutching the manga as if afraid her sister might try to take it back.

Her sister left again, hollering goodbye. The elderly couple paid, carefully buttoned their jackets, and hobbled out. After that we were alone.

She read manga at the register, flipping pages with a steady rhythm, occasionally smiling or pouting. I typed code on my computer between bites of scone. The rays of sunlight rotated across the teahouse as the sun crossed the sky. She didn’t know me, anything about me, couldn’t have cared less about my presence there. But, for me, there was something very powerful about the experience. Some days this was my “reason for living.” Just spending time together, quietly, in the same room.

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Later that afternoon a gale blew in a skyful of dark indigo clouds tinged with gray. A toddler in a colorful parka creaked past the teahouse on a tricycle, in reverse, not even touching the pedals, getting buffeted straight backward by the wind. By then the teaista’s shift had ended, and I had missed all my classes. Yes, grades this semester were going to be dismal. I ordered some takeaway, kukicha, which was prepared by the teaista’s replacement, a tattooed man with a blinking tic. Sipping the tea, huddling into the warmth of the paper cup, I hiked from the teahouse to the nearest metro station. The subway car was crammed with total strangers. I sat there, swaying when the car swayed, jerking when the car jerked, lurching when the car lurched, watching everybody. People in trenchcoats, beige, charcoal, navy. Slumped women sighing murky patches of steam into the scratched windowpanes. Kids in caps, gripping binoculars. An elderly woman hugging a painted canvas wrapped in plastic. I could view the bodies, but didn’t know what was in any of the

heads. It broke my heart. I wanted access.

My whole childhood, bouncing from foster home to foster home, my dream had been to become a hacker. You could learn the basics online, but advanced techniques required a teacher, a master of the craft. Sensei was legendary. He had hacked military installations in Louisiana, agricultural companies in Nebraska, banking conglomerates in Virginia and Minnesota and Pennsylvania, had written enchanting bewitching scripts that could snare the heart of any computer, revolutionary masterpieces of code. Every skiddie had heard of him. So when from my sophomore dormitory, through a combination of basic hacking techniques, I had blundered onto what seemed to be sensei's billing address (for a plush bathrobe from an online merchant) and had realized that he lived, not only in my state, not only in my city, but only a few neighborhoods beyond campus, I grabbed my lanyard with its keys and tumbled out the doorway and ran without sneakers wearing only socks through a dawn fog down streets coated with pale gold and dark gold and bright scarlet leaves, and, panting, sweating, trembling, rang the buzzer for his apartment. A typed label taped under the buzzer revealed the name of the tenant hidden within. Sensei's name was unusual enough I was almost certain the tenant was him. And I had heard recordings of sensei's voice, manifestos on hacktivism that every skiddie had memorized, delivered by a gruff fiery voice with foreign undertones, and when that voice spoke to me from the speaker above the buzzer, then, then, then, I was absolutely certain. The voice told me to get lost. I begged the speaker to accept me as an apprentice, and after that the voice went silent. I rang the buzzer, again and again and again, and was given no response. Then, a returning dogwalker let herself and her pug into the building, and I slipped through the door and snooped around the stairwell and found sensei's apartment. I knocked. Through the flimsy wood of the door, sensei shouted at me to go away. For seventeen hours I knelt on the straw mat there, head bowed to the mat, palms spread across the coarse straw

fibers, in the dark, listening to raindrops thrumming against windows, the pattering of footsteps as other tenants came and went, the pipes thocking within the papery walls of the stairwell, trying not to nod off, silently begging to be accepted, until, around midnight, sensei tripped over me as he left the apartment with a bulging bag of trash. “What, you, still?” sensei cried, splayed backward across the landing, covered in potato peels and lemon rind. The bag had split. He gave me a broom to sweep the trash, which had been my first chore.

Sensei’s motives were political. “Our government’s been hacked by corporations! We have a duty to hack them back!” Despite his age, and his health, he considered himself a vigilante, “not unlike a caped crusader.” He had once sworn to me that he was “going to save the planet, and this nation, and at least a billion children.” I really admired that, obviously. My motives were completely different though. For me, hacking was social. I just wanted to find people to love. Sensei considered this ambition “idiotic.” Stepping from the subway car to the underground platform, I was struck by a vision of sensei pacing his kitchen with that mask of the goateed face hanging from his neck as he scolded me, “You’re wasting your time! You’ve got the talent to make something happen!” Remembering that lecture made me miss him.

Aboveground, flags were snapping against flagpoles. People whose faces were wrapped with scarves hustled across the crosswalks, hunched forward into the wind. Downtown was busy, even for downtown. I could smell the sea: saltwater, and that rich loamy smell that gathered in the depths of empty seashells, abandoned homes. The wind cut through the worn khaki of my coat, making me shiver. I tugged the hood, lined with fur, over my head.

In the porthole windows of a candlelit pub, a retired electrician I followed was splitting a foamy pint with the man he loved who didn’t yet love him. In the lavish offices of a glass

skyscraper, an overworked editor I followed was firing a subordinate whom she thought of as a son, which she had been dreading nauseously for days. In the dim backseat of a braked sedan, an unemployed scion I followed was revising jokes for a stand-up routine he performed every weekend at a local club, under a stage name. They weren't what I was looking for. I kept trekking. Past dappled horses towing carriages of beaming tourists, past vendors sprinkling fried dough with powdered sugar, through windswept alleyways and vacant parking lots.

Until there she was. A girl on a deserted playground, perched in the shadowed hollow of a concrete tube. The blader. What was in her head just then? The same thing as almost always.

<head> daydream </head>

Whenever she daydreamed, she would take on a certain expression, part squint, part glower, completely glazed over. That was the expression she now wore. She had been sick, so couldn't breathe through her nose, was breathing through her mouth instead. She lay sprawled against the side of the tube, staring out and up at the sky, with the shadow draped across her body like a blanket. She was highly active digitally—wrote notes to herself on her phone, used scores of social apps, frequented chat rooms and message boards under pseudonymous usernames. I had discovered the subject of her daydreams while hacking her. Her daydreams followed a single theme. Trying to imagine what her parents might look like, sorting through the infinite possible versions of those faces—infinite, but all variations on her own face, that face now being displayed to me.

<body> bangs irises <u>cheekbones</u> snubnose <i>teeth</i>

<s>chin</s> neck </body>

Then a mob of boys on skateboards clattered into the playground and chased her from the tube, shouting twisted versions of her name.

She hurried off, not rollerblading, instead clutching a skate in each hand. Earlier today, she had ripped her jeans and had scraped her knees. The scar, that pink lump struck across her chin, was from a fall too, though years before. Her sweatshirt was the same size as mine, for a body half the size, and she wore no coat. Her adoptive parents had offered to get her braces for her teeth any number of times, yet she “totally refused,” for reasons that she herself didn’t fully understand but that were likely related to her daydreams: protective of her face, not wanting to change a thing, if that was her only clue to the faces of her birth parents. She tripped on a crumpled magazine, kicked at a pecking seagull, hurried across an intersection of honking trucks. I followed at a distance, sipping kukicha. The city was made of mirrors: shimmering windows, domed bells on the handlebars of chained bicycles, bent bumpers on parked taxis, polished brass address plates on marble columns, curved mirrors above banking machines, swinging glass doorways, ticketed glass windshields, glass smudged with handprints over posters billing upcoming movies, cracked glass over expired advertisements. I watched without watching, my reflections following her reflections. She wasn’t as easy to love as the teaista. The blader was very, very, very angry. She insulted everybody, constantly, including herself, and hated everybody, consistently, including herself, and used both racial and gendered slurs. Once she had noticed me reading a textbook in the park, had not particularly discreetly snapped a photo of my face with her phone, and later had posted the photo to her blog with a caption mocking my birthmark. But, also, I understood why she was angry. When I was her age, I had been very, very, very angry too. Her daydreams were “a new thing.” She had “just never really

thought” much before about her birth parents. Now she wanted, “needed,” their identities. Her adoptive parents didn’t want her to know though, had told her that once she was an adult she could do anything she wanted, but that until then their decision “was final.” I saw what they didn’t. Not knowing was killing her. She wouldn’t last until she was an adult—by then the anger would have eaten her alive. In her life she had overcome only ordinary obstacles: bullies, influenza, spurned crushes, an appendectomy for appendicitis, the trauma of witnessing a deer suddenly get slaughtered by a minivan on the highway. She was unexceptionally heroic, which seemed exceptionally heroic. To watch her skate was heartstopping.

She crossed an overlook at the edge of the park, trotted down a steep zigzag of stone steps to the plaza below, and settled onto a bench. This plaza was her absolute favorite spot for skating, and the overlook my absolute favorite spot for watching. But tonight, rather than lacing into her skates, she slumped backward, facing away from me, off toward the common. Lost herself in daydreams again. Brooding. I sat on the overlook high above, resting on a stone railing blemished with blackened splotches of spit gum. The blader was the reason why I hadn’t given up yet on the script—the script I had been troubleshooting at the teahouse—the script I was writing to hack that hospital. The script was maddeningly, humiliatingly, brutally difficult. I would have quit trying to figure it out weeks ago if it hadn’t been for her. But I couldn’t let myself quit. She had been born in that hospital. I was trying to get her the names of her parents.

She still hadn’t moved. She was especially moody tonight, even for her. I wished I had something that I could drop for her to find—a vintage track ribbon, an antique war pendant, anything that she might like—but I had only my backpack, with my mask and my computer and my notepads and my textbooks, and my now empty paper cup. I didn’t have any cash. I didn’t even have a coin.

I glanced toward the stone steps, where a vast flock of pigeons had gathered, silently, as if amassing forces on the eve of some coup.

I tightened the straps of my backpack and rushed at the flock with a growl, sending the pigeons hopping, then waddling, and then with a frantic loosing of beating wings leaping into flight.

It wasn't much, but was enough.

Below, the blader rose from the bench—watching as shapeshifting flickering networks of pigeons shot across the plaza, a lopsided smile forming on her face, awestruck—and then stuffed her feet into her skates to join all that whirling movement.

I left the blader there. I was ready now to head back toward campus. I was starving. I threw my cup away, hiking off into the park, toward the nearest metro station, which was across the common.

The wind had died. The seemingly imminent rainstorm had dissipated, leaving a frigid twilight of scattered clouds. Glassy puddles of snowmelt glinted on the path. The oaks and the elms, leafless, were transforming to silhouettes. Stars were revealing themselves. A satellite.

After what had happened with the pigeons, I was feeling very content, was feeling really calm, and so was completely unprepared for what happened next.

Crossing the bridge over the lagoon, I realized that somebody was chasing me.

Somebody in a black suit. Clacking along the pavement. Clutching a swinging briefcase. Wearing a mask of a pale, flushed, goateed face.

I stopped, stunned. I realized, then, that some part of me had never expected for me to find sensei—that some part of me had always been waiting for sensei to find me.

Why was he running?

Would we have to run somewhere together?

I gripped the railing, bracing myself for whatever was coming next.

He reached the bridge, shoved between a pair of women with strollers, bumped a jogger, stumbled, glanced back, kept running—there was a moment, at the center of the bridge, when his tie touched my sweatshirt, our bodies were linked—and ran on past me, bolting toward the park gates.

My entire body had gone weak. I felt crushed: initially, as he flew past, because I believed that sensei had failed to recognize me; then, watching him running away, because I realized he had never been sensei at all. Even if the hair was a toupee—sensei was completely bald—the length of the ears, the width of the shoulders, the height of the legs, were all wrong. The posture. The gait.

And, obviously, sensei had left his mask behind.

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I rode the subway back to school, ate a bowl of stew in the cafeteria, printed a history handout in the library. Before leaving, I got online to check the people I followed. The air outside was damp and tart and crisp. Somebody had draped a kimono over the statue in the courtyard. Kids toting liquor bottles, dribbling basketballs, giggling into phones, were streaming into the dormitories. I rented a studio, off-campus, alone.

Leaving campus, I spotted a pair of goateed masks—that same face—hanging from the bushes, as if dumped there by fleeing hackers. Or, maybe, tipsy partiers, ditching costumes, stumbling off to some hookup. If the hacktivist collective had held an event tonight, I hadn't heard.

Dusk had come. My breath had turned to clouds. I was exhausted. As I walked, my head was bent at the sidewalk, viewing nothing but cracks and stones. Mentally, I scrolled

through the various things I'd learned at the library. The teaista was eating salted popcorn ("organic!"), watching what had been her mother's favorite movie, preparing for the anniversary. The blader was getting a skate with loose wheels repaired by her parents ("they've got no clue what they're doing but they're trying anyway"). The mail carrier I followed had survived knee surgery. The bank teller I followed had survived heart surgery. The rooftop beekeepers I followed had found a shop that might sell their honey. Everybody was still here. Boston had survived another day.

Shuffling past the building where sensei lived, I heard a mewing. The tabby cat darted from the alley between the pawnshop and the pharmacy, across the street, over the curb. Before I could even speak, it brushed against me, rubbing my shins through my jeans, mewing again.

This attention wasn't unwelcome, but was unusual, definitely. Aside from mealtimes, the chef usually just got ignored. And typically petting of any sort was strictly verboten. Tonight, though, something seemed different. I decided to try. I knelt. The tabby came around, nudged straight into my hands. As my fingers ran along its back, its spine arched, following my fingertips. The tabby was trembling, as if scared almost.

I glanced at the building where sensei lived—noticed, on the fourth story, the window was glowing. I stopped petting the tabby. I stared at the window. I knew that light—that certain pinkish luster cast onto the kitchen ceiling through the patterned lampshade on the lamp. Either I had left the lamp lit, or somebody had broken into sensei's apartment.

The tabby bolted.

The warped monstrous shadow of a body slid across the kitchen ceiling.

Somebody was breaking into sensei's apartment.

I ran, yanked the hood of my coat over my head, didn't need the keys that sensei had given me—the door was ajar, a squirrel had crept into the building to inspect the rug in

the entryway, I leapt the squirrel and launched myself up the staircase hitting only every other step and with the railing used my momentum to whip around the landing on the second story sending a mat there skidding and launched myself up the staircase with my backpack thudding against my back and with the railing used my momentum to whip around the landing on the third story almost overshooting nearly throwing myself into a potted fern there and slipped and cursed and recovered and launched myself up the staircase, but then froze—panting, crouching, suddenly thinking, I took the last few steps to the landing on the fourth story very quietly, so I could ambush whoever had broken into the apartment rather than getting ambushed myself.

The door to sensei's apartment was ajar too—record albums scattered across the futon, rumpled sweaters strewn across the floor, a mirror overturned, the drawers yanked from the cupboard and lying upended haphazardly in the hallway—sensei was getting ransacked.

Then—the exact moment I heard the voice, muttering, a gruff fiery voice with foreign undertones—I saw him, in the kitchen, hunched over a duffel bag.

Sensei was getting ransacked by sensei.

“Sensei?” I said, shoving down the hood of my coat.

He yelped, fumbled something, whirled about.

What was in his head just then? Exactly one thing I wanted.

<head> answers </head>

“Where have you been?” I said, stepping into the apartment over a pair of clayey boots with frayed laces. I felt intensely relieved that he was back—but, also, weirdly upset that he had made such a mess of the apartment. For five weeks this place had been spotless.

“You’re here, you’re here, you’re here!” sensei murmured, rising up, throwing the duffel bag over his back. He clapped my elbows with his hands. I had forgotten how tiny his body was.

<body> scalp wrinkles brow <object>bandage</object>
<object>eyeglasses</object> <i>nose</i> <s>dimples</s> stubble mouth
shoulders breastbone nipples <u>ribs</u> navel hips
<object>belt</object> <object>slacks</object> ankles veins toenails </body>

A broom tipped, clattered to the floor, and he gasped and flinched and leapt back from the noise. I hadn’t seen him like this before—he was generally very calm, never edgy. He tossed the duffel bag onto the counter and began rooting through a drawer. He had a limp, I noticed. A teacup containing a last swig of tea sat by the lamp on the table. Genmaicha, from the look. Very sensei. As frantic as he seemed, he had taken the time to make a pot of tea.

He stuffed a rusted can opener into the duffel bag.

“Kid,” he said.

“What happened to your head?” I said.

“It’s the end of the world,” he said.

“Why are you limping?” I said.

“The meteors are falling, the tsunamis are coming, the volcanoes are about to blow.”

“You haven’t even been blogging,” I said.

Sensei had hurried into the hallway. “The blog,” he laughed, bitterly, muffled, his head stuck in the depths of the closet. “The blog’s finished.”

“What do you mean, finished?” I said.

“I’m shutting it down,” he called, pulling a brown wool cap onto his head, rushing into the bathroom. “I’m shutting it all down.”

In the bathroom, he reached into the cabinet and stripped an envelope from the underside of the sink. That cabinet beneath the sink was where I kept all my cleaning supplies. Somehow, though, I had never spotted the envelope taped there.

“Did something happen?” I said.

He was back in the kitchen, had crammed the envelope into the duffel bag.

“I want you to know that I’m proud of you,” he said. He yanked his arms through the sleeves of a cardigan, shook the cardigan on. His mask, his computer, his jacket lay jumbled together in the duffel bag. A metal flashlight. A toothbrush with kinked bristles. I noticed suddenly what he was doing. He wasn’t unpacking. He was packing.

He zipped the duffel bag.

“You’re leaving again?” I said.

“Listen, where I’m going, you can’t follow,” he said.

“I’m coming with you,” I said.

“I need you to promise me you won’t even try,” he said.

I hurled my backpack at the futon.

“I’m supposed to be your student,” I shouted.

Sensei buttoned the cardigan. He tugged on a pair of fingerless gloves. He hesitated. Then he finally looked at me.

“Your training’s over,” he said. “You’re a hacker now.”

I couldn’t speak. I should have been happy. Instead, I felt like I’d had some terminal diagnosis and had just been pronounced dead. I didn’t want to be a hacker, if that meant that now sensei could abandon me.

Sensei selected a chipped porcelain teacup with an indigo design from the shelf of

teacups above the table. The tabletop was marked with overlapping pale halos, burned into the wood by the countless cups of tea that had been set there without saucers, as many mine as his. He placed the teacup at the nexus of a few halos. With his back to me, he tipped the teapot, pouring steaming genmaicha from the curved spout into the teacup below, until only drips were left, and then not even drips. The surface of the genmaicha shimmered in the glow of the lamp.

“That’s the last of it,” he murmured. “This cup’s yours.”

He patted my elbows, stomped into the boots in the doorway, threw the duffel bag over his back, and then was gone.

The thoughts and feelings in my head then, they would have broken most machines. I collapsed into a rickety chair, slumped backward, tried and failed to raise my head. I felt like yelling, but couldn’t. I felt like crying, but couldn’t. The lamp had given my coat and my jeans and my sneakers that certain pinkish luster. The tiles were littered with dropped spoons and fallen socks. The radiator was creaking. Outside, a siren wailed, swelled, faded.

There was some voice in my head. This is the very last tea sensei ever made for you, it said. So this here is the most important cup of tea in the history of the world. You’ll have to pay extra careful attention as you drink it, and remember everything about it. And savor every sip. Okay? Hey, hacker? Are you listening?

I wasn’t listening. For a very, very, very long time I stared at the floor. As it happened, I ruined my farewell gift—by the time I came to again, my tea had gone cold.

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About The Author

Matthew Baker is the author of the graphic novel *The Sentence*, the story collections *Why Visit America* and *Hybrid Creatures*, and the children's novel *Key Of X*. Digital experiments include the temporal fiction "Ephemeral," the interlinked novel *Untold*, the randomized novel *Verses*, and the intentionally posthumous *Afterthought*.

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